

**IT IS TIME TO
ACKNOWLEDGE THE ENEMY
BUT KEEP OUR EYES ON THE LORD**

TEXT: Exodus 14:1-4, 8-10, 13-14 (CEV) *“At Etham the LORD said to Moses: ²Tell the people of Israel to turn back and camp across from Pi-Hahiroth (Pee-hah-hi-roth) near Baal-Zephon (Ze-phon), between Migdol and the Red Sea. ³The king will think they were afraid to cross the desert and that they are wandering around, trying to find another way to leave the country. ⁴I will make the king stubborn again, and he will try to catch you. Then I will destroy him and his army. People everywhere will praise me for my victory, and the Egyptians will know that I really am the LORD. The Israelites obeyed the LORD and camped where he told them. 8 The LORD made the king so stubborn that he went after them, even though the Israelites proudly went on their way. ⁹But the king's horses and chariots and soldiers caught up with them while they were camping*

by the Red Sea near Pi-Hahiroth (Pee-hah-hi-roth) and Baal-Zephon (Ze-phon). ¹⁰When the Israelites saw the king coming with his army, they were frightened and begged the LORD for help. ¹³But Moses answered, " Don't be afraid! Be brave, and you will see the LORD save you today. These Egyptians will never bother you again. ¹⁴The LORD will fight for you, and you won't have to do a thing."

INTRO:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN THE ARIEL VIEW OF WHERE ISRAEL CAMPED – THE PICTURE IS IN THE POWER POINT OF 10 STRATEGIES FOR DEALING WITH DIFFICULTY – LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL FURTHER INSTRUCTION)

In this passage of Scripture, the Children of Israel followed God into a cul-de-sac. They find themselves between hostile hills and the edge of a sea too deep to be forded, and too wide to be

crossed. The unmistakable indication of Exodus 14:1-4 is that the Lord took responsibility for leading them into peril. He gave them specific, step-by-step instructions, leading them down a route to apparent ruin: ***“Turn and camp; camp there; there, before the entrapping sea; yes, right there in that impossible place.”***

How could Moses and Aaron keep from worrying when the Red Sea was facing them; the mountains were beside them; the soldiers of Egypt were bearing down on them with swords drawn?

The Egyptians were not one bit concerned about a confrontation with the Israelites because these people had spent the last 400 years living as slaves. Not one of them had been trained in the intricacies of warfare, nor did one of them own a weapon! What the Egyptians did not know is that the Israelites did not need a weapon; they did not need to know how to fight; they had a secret weapon and His name was Jehovah!

What helped create faith in a moment of terror was the fact that they knew Jehovah delivered them from Egypt and that it was His will for them to go to Canaan!

Moses determined that they were where they were not by their own will, but according to the will of God! Please understand that God was not being disingenuous to Israel by having them in such a vulnerable spot:

- He was about to deal with Israel's enemies once and for all!
- He was about to allow them to see Him in a way they had never seen Him before!
- He was about to provide them with weapons to protect themselves, during the forty plus years of wilderness wandering!

Life can be very, very difficult. If we are walking through a difficult spot, we are not so out of step with the general population or the most spiritual people in the Kingdom.

The reason life can be so difficult is because God has appointed a destiny for us and there is a real, live enemy, who will do everything in his power to sabotage and keep us back from reaching our ultimate potential.

(TAKE ARIEL VIEW OF THE ISRAELITES AT THE RED SEA DOWN)

Our enemy is not our parents, professors, boss or the government; our enemy is satan and satan alone! On the other hand, the Lord has committed Himself to being our constant companion and even fighting our battles for us.

The Israelites could have denied the existence of an enemy but that would not have changed the fact that a hostile king was in hot pursuit of this group of emancipated slaves.

Denial of the enemy never calms his hostilities but the acknowledgement of his existence

demands readiness. Charles Spurgeon once said, *“The great tyrant has not forgotten you, and he designs your capture and re-enslavement.”*

When dealing with difficulty, it is time for us to acknowledge our enemy, while keeping our eyes on the Lord.

I want us to consider the parallels between Pharaoh and Satan:

- Both are unyielding enemies!
- Both covet power over their subjects!
- Both are enraged beyond reason!
- Both have assembled vast armies meant for destruction!
- Both will eventually be plundered by the Almighty!

The Bible likens Satan to five different animals:

- In Genesis 3, he's a serpent trying to deceive God's people.

- In Matthew 13, he's a bird trying to defile God's harvest.
- In John 10, He's a wolf attacking God's flock.
- In First Peter, he's a lion trying to devour God's children.
- In Revelation 12, he's a dragon wanting to destroy God's Son.

There is little question with regard to the intentions of our enemy. He is malicious, malignant and venomous. He is not tempting us to allow us to have a good time; he is attempting to drag us down to Hell.

This is not the kind of enemy we can defeat simply with the denial of his presence. Defeating our enemy will require far more than confessing we do not have an adversary!

How do we overcome our opponent?

- The blood of Jesus Christ forgives our sins and resolves our guilt!

- The resurrection frees us from the fear of death, and satisfies our need for eternal significance and happiness!
- The presence of the Lord surrounds us!
- The promises of the Bible sustain us!
- The grace of God heals the wounds this world inflicts upon us!
- Our testimony becomes our triumphant shout and the final nail in the coffin of the enemy!

We can be assured; our enemy will attempt to trap us in our troubles; entangle us in our dilemmas; corner us in an impossible situation; or lure us into temptation.

When threatened by the devils schemes, we should stand on the Word. Daniel 11:32 (CEV) ***“The king will use deceit to win followers from those who are unfaithful to God, but those who remain faithful will do everything possible to oppose him.”*** James 4:7-8 (CEV) ***“Surrender to God! Resist the devil, and he will run from***

you. 8 Come near to God, and he will come near to you. Clean up your lives, you sinners. Purify your hearts, you people who can't make up your mind." 1 Peter 5:9 (CEV) **"But you must resist the devil and stay strong in your faith. You know that all over the world the Lord's followers are suffering just as you are."**

We should resist the enemy in the name of Jesus Christ, we should stand our ground; we should shake off discouragement; when we do this the enemy is doomed to be drowned in the Red Sea of the blood of Jesus Christ.

Every time we resist the slightest temptation, we honor God. Every time we overcome even the smallest problem by trusting and obeying our Lord Jesus, God is glorified in our lives.

Look at the patriarch Job and how he faced his difficulties courageously! In one terrible season:

- He lost his herds to barbarians!

- He lost his children to a tornado!
- He lost his health to a disease!
- He lost his wealth to misfortune!
- He lost his friends to a critical spirit!
- He lost his wife to doubt!

Job seemed to be oblivious to the fact that as he sat among the ashes scraping his boils with pottery shards and bemoaning his fate that an enemy who was bent on destroying his soul had orchestrated his problems. This was nonetheless a fact!

Much to the enemy's chagrin, Job emerged on the other side of the trial with his faith intact, and his attitude optimistic! The reason he was able to persevere is because he knew his time had come to acknowledge the enemy but he kept his eyes on the Lord. ***“Though God slay me yet I will trust him. “If worms destroy this body, I intend to see God face to face.”***

As a result, God gave him twice as much as he had before the trial. He was 70 when the trial began, and he lived to be 210!

The devil came to church one Sunday and started shouting insults at the crowd. Everyone vacated the building except one little old man. The devil shouted to the old man, *“Don’t you know who I am?”* To which the man calmly replied, *“Yes.”* The devil said, *“Are you not afraid of me?”* The man said *“no.”* The devil could not believe his ears and said, *“Why are you not afraid of me?”* The man replied, *“I was married to your sister for fifty-five years!”*

The same devil orchestrates similar attacks against us today. What would be a proper response? We draw near to Christ and keep ourselves under the protective cloud of His grace. Acknowledge the enemy and keep our focus on Jesus!

In Exodus 14, Pharaoh could:

- Threaten with brute force...
- Protest their emancipation...
- Stir up frightening clouds of chariot dust...
- Terrify with a thousand clanging swords...

But he was powerless to actually harm the Israelites as long as they remained under the protective cloud of God's glory and grace. (The Passover was a celebration of emancipation for the Israelites and the cry of a mass funeral to the Egyptians - That cloud became darkness to the Egyptians and light to the Israelites)

As long as we walk in His will there is nothing that hell can devise which will be successful against us! Isaiah 54:17 (NKJV) **“No weapon formed against you shall prosper, And every tongue which rises against you in judgment You shall condemn. This is the heritage of the servants of the LORD, And their righteousness is from Me,” Says the LORD.**”

It is time to acknowledge our enemy while keeping our eyes on the Lord.

The reason the Children of Israel were successful against their enemy at the Red Sea is because Moses and Aaron refused to divert their attention from the Lord to Pharaoh. They acknowledged the pursuit of the Egyptians but decided to focus on what Jehovah was about to do!

CONCLUSION:

Look at the Miracle of the Red Sea crossing:

- The winds blew the sea split!
- The waters congealed into towering walls!
- The Israelites passed through on dry ground!
- Jehovah dried out the Red Sea but did not leave one footprint!

This happened not for the entertainment value of the experience, but to prove to the Israelites and to us, in earth shaking, history-making fashion that; even when we are most anxious

and distressed; God will make a way when there seems to be no way!

Exodus 14 provides us a biblical model of how to properly process difficulties by faith, in the light of God's almighty:

- Presence! He is omnipresent!
- Providence! He is omniscient
- Promise! He is a God who cannot lie!
- Power! He is omnipotent!

The Red Sea may roll before us; the desert may entrap us; the enemy may press on our heels; the past may seem implausible; the future impossible; but God works in ways we cannot see! This one thing I am absolutely sure of, God will make a way of escape for His children!

Isaiah 43:19 (CEV) ***“I am creating something new. There it is! Do you see it? I have put roads in deserts, streams in thirsty lands.”*** 1

Corinthians 10:13 (CEV) ***“You are tempted in the same way that everyone else is tempted. But God can be trusted not to let you be tempted***

too much, and he will show you how to escape from your temptations.” Colossians 4:2-3
(CEV) “***Never give up praying. And when you pray, keep alert and be thankful. 3 Be sure to pray that God will make a way for us to spread his message and explain the mystery about Christ, even though I am in jail for doing this.***” Isaiah 11:15-16 (CEV) “***The Lord will dry up the arm of the Red Sea near Egypt, and he will send a scorching wind to divide the Euphrates River into seven streams that anyone can step across.*** 16 ***Then for his people who survive, there will be a good road from Assyria, just as there was a good road for their ancestors when they left Egypt.***”

Remember:

- There's more forgiveness in His sacrifice than the collective sins of the universe from the beginning of time...
- There's more provision in His sacrifice than there is needs in the entirety of the world...
- There's more peace in His provision than all

the turmoil in all of our problems...

- There's more healing in one drop of His blood than all the pain of all the problems of humankind...

There's

- No sea is deeper than the ocean of His love!
- No army is stronger than His hosts!
- No force is greater than His throne of grace!
- No enemy exists who can overcome His direct and indirect work in our lives!

David said in Psalms 23:6 (NKJV) “***Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me All the days of my life.***” (Use three students to illustrate this)